

to pay attention to rotations per minute (rpm), which tells you how fast the hard disk is rotating. The higher the rpm, the faster the data transfer and the PC's operating speed. Another thing you need to look for is the sustained transfer rate of the drive. Measured in Megabytes per second (MBps), the higher the number, the faster is the disk operation.

Though most drives run at 5,400 rpm, some of the faster and commonly available hard disks run at 7,200 rpm, while there are others which run at 10,000 rpm and higher. Some of the popular hard disks available in the market are 30 GB HDDs running at 7,200 RPM and 40 GB HDDs running at 5,400 rpm. These drives are available for less than Rs 7,000 and the prices are expected to fall further.

Go for video

Next on the upgrade chart is the video card. If you are one of those avid gamer types, then this is a part that you need to upgrade on a regular basis. For lesser mortals, a video card upgrade wouldn't be that frequent.

If your video card still has less than 8 MB of video RAM, it's definitely worth upgrading to a 16 MB TNT card or higher. This should end up costing you around Rs 3,000 and will give you significantly improved performance with newer Operating Systems like the Windows XP.

In a graphics card, the main features you should be looking out for are 3D acceleration and TV input/output. However, if you are not an avid gamer with lots of money to spend, upgrading to a video card in the higher spectrum would be pointless.

Size matters

You could probably consider upgrading your monitor if you're tired of the 14-inch screen. You can get a 17-inch monitor at a decent price of Rs 12,000. The prices of bigger monitors like 19-inch and 21-inch have also come down. You should opt for them if you watch a lot of movies and your budget permits it. Graphics designers will obviously welcome a better reproduction of their art on these monitors. If you're lucky, you could also get a buyback deal which would give you a decent value for your existing monitor.

Processor-motherboard combo

In many cases upgrading to the latest processor might not be feasible because it would involve purchasing a new motherboard. However, if you use a 440BX/ZX based socket 370 motherboard



"I upgraded the RAM on my PC from 128 MB to 256 MB and installed a CD-RW drive. The entire process took 15 to 20 minutes"

Pratik Shah

Graphics designer

with 100 MHz FSB (Front Side Bus) support and can get your hands on a Pentium III 800 MHz processor, this is a good idea.

In most cases where you have an old 500 MHz or lower processor, using a Slot 1 or Slot A interface might not make as much sense as getting yourself a new PC. This is because a motherboard upgrade coupled with the cost of the processor would end up being pretty expensive anyway.

Write and read more

Another upgrade option you might want to consider is replacing your low speed CD-ROM drive with a model that is faster. Better still, you could go in for a CD-RW or DVD-ROM drive, both of which are quite reasonably priced nowadays.

Getting hold of a faster CD-ROM drive is worth it if you're still working with an 8x CD-ROM drive or something of that order. And if you've made CD writing your new hobby, replacing your old CD-ROM with a CD-RW is a good idea for burning all those MP3s you've been collecting.

For movie buffs with access to DVDs, a DVD-ROM drive would be a nice option. However, you should be aware that while you could get one of these for as little as Rs 5,500, you could face problems due to DVD region coding.

Get her grooving

And there you go! That's all there is to upgrading your PC. Giving your darling machine a boost in its performance is always a good deed and all you need to do is ensure is that you upgrade as per your performance requirements. Can't wait to hear your machine start purring again, can you? 

Watch out for this

As in the case with most maintenance operations, upgrading a PC also involves taking some necessary safety measures.

If this is the first time you are upgrading your PC, do not attempt to do it all by yourself. Make sure you have an experienced person supervising while you do it. Otherwise, the next best thing is to get the upgrades done by a hardware engineer.

However, if you have decided on doing the upgrade yourself, here's what you should watch out for:

- Make sure you get rid of static charges by touching the bare (non-powder coated) surface of your metal cabinet.
- Handle most of the card components such as RAM, motherboard, soundcard, etc by their edges. This will ensure that the card does not get damaged due to static electrical charges built up in it.
- Done with the installs? Check that all the connectors and cards are in place. There should be no loose contacts anywhere in the system.

Finally, switch on the PC. If everything's been done right, you should hear a short, single beep. If the system hangs, it could be due to incorrect motherboard settings or loose cards. Check these out thoroughly and rectify the faults before you go any further.